

ARTICULATE

A Five-Week Communication & Soft Skills Program

A One-on-One Facilitation Curriculum for Adult English Learners

Course Plan • Curriculum • Detailed Syllabus • Session Plans
Facilitation Guide • Assessment Framework • Resource Bank

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PART I

Course Overview & Instructional Design Rationale

1.1 About This Course

ARTICULATE is a five-week, one-on-one communication program designed for adult English learners who wish to develop their capacity to express themselves with confidence, clarity, and depth. Unlike traditional English courses, ARTICULATE contains no grammar instruction, no vocabulary lists, and no formal linguistic exercises. Instead, every session is structured around authentic human conversation: learners and facilitators discuss meaningful topics, explore personal narratives, examine articles and books, and engage in the kind of exchange that naturally develops communicative fluency.

The course is built on a foundational belief: fluency is not primarily a linguistic achievement. It is a social, emotional, and intellectual one. When a person can listen actively, articulate their values, defend a position with grace, empathize with a perspective different from their own, and speak about their future with conviction — they are communicating effectively. ARTICULATE is designed to build precisely these capacities.

The course is organized around five thematic weeks, each exploring a different dimension of the human experience. Within each week, three one-on-one sessions of approximately 50 to 60 minutes each guide the learner through progressively deeper engagement with the week's theme. Every session follows a consistent three-part structure: a warm-up to ease into the topic, a core discussion to develop it, and a reflective activity to synthesize the learning.

1.2 Instructional Design Methodology

This course was designed using a layered instructional design framework that combines three complementary approaches: the ADDIE Model as the overarching process, Backward Design (Understanding by Design) as the curriculum planning strategy, and a blend of Communicative Language Teaching and Dogme ELT as the pedagogical philosophy.

The ADDIE Model

The ADDIE Model — Analysis, Design, Development, Implementation, and Evaluation — provides the meta-framework for this project. Each phase informed specific decisions:

- **Analysis:** The course begins with a learner profile assessment. Before Session 1, the facilitator completes a Student Profile Form to identify interests, communication goals, and soft skills development priorities. This ensures that the curriculum adapts to the individual rather than imposing a generic learning path.
- **Design:** Sessions are structured using Backward Design (see below), moving from desired outcomes to learning experiences. The thematic architecture across five weeks was designed to progressively build learner capacity from self-expression to social and professional communication, culminating in a synthesizing capstone.
- **Development:** Each session plan provides a full facilitation guide, including warm-up prompts, discussion questions, a structured activity, a soft skills observation focus, and wrap-up reflection.

A Resource Bank provides curated readings, TED Talks, and articles that facilitators can use or substitute based on learner preference.

- **Implementation:** The course is delivered one-on-one by a trained facilitator. The Facilitation Guide in Part V equips instructors with strategies for creating a psychologically safe environment, managing silence, adapting to different communication styles, and using readings to spark authentic dialogue rather than instruction.
- **Evaluation:** Assessment in this course is non-linguistic and non-graded. The Assessment Framework in Part VI provides a Soft Skills Observation Rubric, a session progress notes template, and an end-of-course reflection guide. Evaluation measures growth in communicative behaviors — listening, articulation, confidence, empathy, and critical thinking — not grammatical accuracy.

Backward Design (Understanding by Design — Wiggins & McTighe)

Following the UbD framework, each week and session was designed by first identifying the desired end result — what the learner should be able to do, feel, or articulate as a result of the experience — and then working backward to determine what learning experiences would produce that outcome.

This approach is evident in the structure of each session, which begins with a clearly stated soft skills objective. Questions and activities are chosen not because they cover "content," but because they create the conditions under which the target communicative behavior is most likely to emerge organically.

Communicative Language Teaching (CLT) & Dogme ELT

At the pedagogical level, the course draws on Communicative Language Teaching and its radical extension, Dogme ELT (Thornbury & Meddings, 2002). CLT holds that the goal of language instruction is communicative competence — the ability to use language effectively in real social contexts — and that this competence is best developed through authentic interaction, not through the study of linguistic rules.

Dogme ELT extends this principle further by advocating for "conversation-driven" teaching that is deliberately stripped of dependency on published materials, grammar presentations, and pre-planned linguistic targets. In Dogme, the content of the lesson emerges from what the learner brings to the interaction. ARTICULATE operationalizes this philosophy by placing the learner's interests, experiences, and opinions at the center of every session. Readings and articles are offered as launching pads for conversation, not as texts to be analyzed linguistically.

Additional Theoretical Underpinnings

- **Krashen's Input Hypothesis & Affective Filter Hypothesis:** The course is designed to provide rich, comprehensible input through authentic discussion — the condition Krashen argues is essential for language acquisition. Equally important is the Affective Filter Hypothesis: learners acquire language most readily when they feel safe, respected, and engaged. The one-on-one format, the absence of error correction, and the focus on meaningful topics are all deliberate strategies to lower the affective filter.
- **Carl Rogers' Humanistic Education:** The course positions the facilitator as a companion in learning rather than an authority figure. Consistent with Rogers' person-centered approach, the

facilitators role is to listen, reflect, encourage, and follow the learner's lead — not to evaluate or correct. The course treats the learner as a whole person whose experiences, values, and perspectives are legitimate and valuable.

- **Kolb's Experiential Learning Cycle:** Each session follows the logic of Kolb's cycle: the learner has a concrete experience (the discussion), reflects on it (wrap-up), forms new connections (the activity), and can apply insights in future interactions. This cycle supports durable learning that extends beyond the classroom.
- **Bloom's Affective Domain:** Many language programs engage Bloom's cognitive domain. ARTICULATE deliberately targets the affective domain: valuing, organizing personal beliefs, internalizing values, and responding with genuine engagement. This is the domain through which soft skills are actually developed.

1.3 Target Learner Profile

ARTICULATE is designed for adult English learners who have achieved sufficient communicative competence to engage in sustained conversation on a range of topics. The course is not appropriate for complete beginners; it assumes that the learner can express basic ideas and follow a conversation, even if imperfectly.

The ideal learner is motivated by a desire to communicate more confidently, persuasively, and authentically in English — whether in professional, social, or academic contexts. They may be intermediate to advanced speakers who feel that their linguistic skills outpace their ability to use language for complex self-expression: to tell their story, defend a position, give feedback, or inspire others.

Learner Entry Profile

- Intermediate to advanced English proficiency (B1+ on the CEFR scale or equivalent)
- Adult (18+), with life experience sufficient to engage meaningfully with the course themes
- Motivated by communication goals beyond grammatical accuracy (e.g., professional development, personal expression, social confidence)
- Willing to engage in reflective conversation, share opinions, and discuss personal perspectives
- No prior English course required; this course may be used as a standalone program or alongside other instruction

1.4 Learning Outcomes

By the end of the five-week program, the learner will demonstrate measurable growth in the following six soft skills competencies:

- **1. Self-Awareness & Expression:** The ability to articulate personal identity, values, and experiences with clarity and confidence.
- **2. Active Listening:** The ability to remain fully present in dialogue, respond thoughtfully to what is being said, and demonstrate genuine engagement.
- **3. Empathy & Emotional Intelligence:** The ability to identify and articulate the emotional dimensions of communication and to adapt one's approach to the perspective of others.

- **4. Critical Thinking & Argumentation:** The ability to form, express, support, and revise a position in response to ideas and evidence.
- **5. Professional Communication:** The ability to adapt register and purpose to professional contexts, including giving and receiving feedback, self-positioning, and influencing through language.
- **6. Confidence & Authentic Voice:** The ability to speak with conviction, specificity, and personal authority on topics that matter to the learner.

A Note on Assessment

These outcomes are not assessed linguistically. The Soft Skills Observation Rubric in Part VI describes behavioral indicators for each competency — what the learner does, not how correctly they say it. Facilitators observe and document these behaviors session by session, creating a portrait of communicative growth over five weeks.

PART II

Curriculum Architecture

2.1 The Soft Skills Framework

ARTICULATE is structured around six core communicative soft skills. These are not discrete units to be taught in sequence; rather, they function as threads woven throughout all fifteen sessions. Each session foregrounds one or two skills while the others remain present in the background of the conversation.

Competency	Description	Sessions Where Foregrounded
Self-Awareness & Expression	Articulating identity, values, and personal narrative with clarity	Sessions 1, 2, 3, 13, 15
Active Listening	Full engagement in dialogue; building on what is heard	Sessions 6, 4, 9, 15
Empathy & Emotional Intelligence	Perspective-taking; adapting communication to emotional context	Sessions 4, 5, 6, 10
Critical Thinking & Argumentation	Forming, expressing, defending, and revising positions	Sessions 10, 11, 12, 14
Professional Communication	Register, influence, feedback, and self-positioning	Sessions 7, 8, 9
Confidence & Authentic Voice	Speaking with conviction and personal authority	Sessions 1, 7, 13, 14, 15

2.2 The Five-Week Thematic Arc

Each week is built around a central theme that organizes the three sessions within it. The themes are sequenced to move from the internal (self) to the interpersonal (relationships) to the professional (work) to the intellectual (ideas) to the aspirational (future). This arc mirrors natural human development and progressively expands the scope of what the learner is asked to communicate about.

Week	Theme	Core Question	Soft Skills Focus
Week 1	WHO ARE YOU?	How do you tell the story of yourself?	Self-expression · Storytelling · Authenticity
Week 2	THE ART OF CONNECTION	How do you understand and reach others?	Empathy · Active Listening · Conflict Navigation

Week	Theme	Core Question	Soft Skills Focus
Week 3	WORK & AMBITION	How do you communicate in professional life?	Professional Communication · Influence · Feedback
Week 4	THINKING & PERSUADING	How do you engage with ideas in the world?	Critical Thinking · Argumentation · Media Literacy
Week 5	VISION & IMPACT	What do you want to say, and why does it matter?	Vision · Advocacy · Authentic Voice · Synthesis

2.3 Curriculum Map

The following table presents the complete curriculum at a glance — all fifteen sessions mapped across the five weeks, with their themes, soft skills, and suggested reading sources.

Week	Session	Title	Soft Skill Focus	Suggested Reading / Resource
1	Session 1	Your Story So Far	Storytelling, Self-Expression	"The Power of Vulnerability" — TED Talk, Brené Brown
1	Session 2	What Matters Most	Values Articulation, Authenticity	Core Values Reflection List (included in Resource Bank)
1	Session 3	Habits & the Self	Self-Awareness, Reflective Thinking	Atomic Habits, James Clear (Ch. 1–2)
2	Session 4	Seeing Through Another's Eyes	Empathy, Perspective-Taking	"Brené Brown on Empathy" — RSA Animate (3 min)
2	Session 5	When Words Fail	Assertive Communication, Conflict Navigation	"How to Have a Difficult Conversation" — HBR Article
2	Session 6	The Listening Advantage	Active Listening, Rapport-Building	Just Listen, Mark Goulston (selected excerpt)
3	Session 7	Your Professional Identity	Professional Presence, Self-Positioning	"Find Your Why" article or Start With Why — Sinek
3	Session 8	Leadership in Words & Action	Leadership Communication, Influence	Leaders Eat Last or Start With Why — Simon Sinek
3	Session 9	Feedback as a Gift	Giving/Receiving Feedback, Growth Mindset	Radical Candor, Kim Scott (selected excerpt)
4	Session 10	The News & You	Media Literacy, Opinion Formation	Current news article (facilitator selects based on learner interest)

Week	Session	Title	Soft Skill Focus	Suggested Reading / Resource
4	Session 11	Agree to Disagree	Argumentation, Intellectual Humility	Opinion piece selected by learner or facilitator
4	Session 12	Books That Changed You	Critical Reflection, Idea Synthesis	Passage chosen by learner (pre-assigned in Session 11)
5	Session 13	Your Future Self	Visioning, Aspirational Communication	The 7 Habits — Covey (Begin with the End in Mind)
5	Session 14	One Conversation at a Time	Advocacy, Passionate Communication	TED Talk transcript on social topic of learner's choice
5	Session 15	My Personal Manifesto	Synthesis · All Six Competencies	No assigned reading — learner-led capstone session

Flexibility Note for Facilitators

The curriculum map above represents the recommended sequence. However, ARTICULATE is a flexible framework. If a learner is deeply engaged in a topic that spans two sessions, extend it. If a session's reading does not resonate, substitute a different text from the Resource Bank. The session plans include a "Facilitator Adaptation Note" with suggestions for customizing each session to individual learner needs and interests.

PART III

Course Syllabus — Week by Week

3.0 Syllabus Overview

The following pages present the detailed syllabus for each of the five weeks. Each week overview includes the thematic focus, the central question guiding the week, the learning outcomes, and a brief description of the three sessions within it. Full session plans are provided in Part IV.

WEEK 1

WHO ARE YOU? — Self, Identity & Personal Expression

The Central Question for Week 1

"What is your story, and how do you tell it?"

Overview

Week 1 sets the tone for the entire course. The three sessions in this week invite the learner to turn their attention inward — to explore and articulate who they are, what they value, and how they engage with the world. The facilitator's role this week is above all relational: to create a space of genuine curiosity and warmth in which the learner feels safe to share and reflect.

Week 1 Learning Outcomes

By the end of Week 1, the learner will be able to:

- Articulate a personal narrative with coherence and emotional range
- Identify and verbalize core personal values
- Reflect on the role of habits and routines in shaping identity

Sessions at a Glance

Session	Title	Soft Skill Focus
Session 1	Your Story So Far	Storytelling · Self-expression
Session 2	What Matters Most	Values articulation · Authenticity
Session 3	Habits & the Self	Self-awareness · Reflective thinking

WEEK 2

THE ART OF CONNECTION — Relationships, Empathy & Human Understanding

The Central Question for Week 2

"How do you reach people, and how do they reach you?"

Overview

Week 2 shifts the focus outward. The learner is invited to consider how they relate to others — how they listen, how they respond to conflict, and how they build genuine connection. These sessions tend to generate some of the most meaningful conversations in the course, as they invite the learner to reflect on their relational patterns and the role communication plays in sustaining or repairing relationships.

Week 2 Learning Outcomes

By the end of Week 2, the learner will be able to:

- Demonstrate perspective-taking through language and response
- Discuss conflict navigation strategies with examples from personal experience
- Reflect on their own listening habits and identify areas for growth

Sessions at a Glance

Session	Title	Soft Skill Focus
Session 4	Seeing Through Another's Eyes	Empathy · Perspective-taking
Session 5	When Words Fail	Assertive communication · Conflict navigation
Session 6	The Listening Advantage	Active listening · Rapport-building

WEEK 3

WORK & AMBITION — Professional Identity, Leadership & Feedback

The Central Question for Week 3

"Who are you at work, and how do you lead and grow?"

Overview

Week 3 moves into the professional domain. For many learners, the workplace represents the context in which clear, confident communication matters most — and also where it is most fraught. These three sessions explore professional identity, leadership communication, and the art of giving and receiving feedback. The facilitator can personalize these sessions significantly based on the learner's professional context.

Week 3 Learning Outcomes

By the end of Week 3, the learner will be able to:

- Articulate their professional identity and personal "why" with clarity
- Discuss leadership communication strategies using personal examples
- Practice giving and receiving feedback using constructive, specific language

Sessions at a Glance

Session	Title	Soft Skill Focus
Session 7	Your Professional Identity	Professional presence · Self-positioning
Session 8	Leadership in Words & Action	Leadership communication · Influence
Session 9	Feedback as a Gift	Feedback delivery & reception · Growth mindset

WEEK 4

THINKING & PERSUADING — Critical Thinking, Media & Argumentation

The Central Question for Week 4

"What do you think, and how do you make your case?"

Overview

Week 4 is intellectually the most demanding. Learners are invited to engage with ideas in the public sphere — to analyze media, form and defend opinions, and experience the productive friction of intellectual disagreement. These sessions develop the learner's capacity for structured argumentation and intellectual humility: the twin engines of sophisticated communication.

Week 4 Learning Outcomes

By the end of Week 4, the learner will be able to:

- Distinguish between fact, opinion, and interpretation in spoken and written sources
- Present and defend a position using evidence and reasoning
- Demonstrate intellectual humility by acknowledging alternative perspectives

Sessions at a Glance

Session	Title	Soft Skill Focus
Session 10	The News & You	Media literacy · Structured opinion formation
Session 11	Agree to Disagree	Debate · Persuasion · Intellectual humility
Session 12	Books That Changed You	Critical reflection · Idea synthesis

WEEK 5

VISION & IMPACT — Aspiration, Advocacy & Communicative Synthesis

The Central Question for Week 5

"What is your message, and why does it matter?"

Overview

Week 5 brings the course full circle. Building on everything explored in the previous four weeks, the learner is invited to look forward — to articulate a vision, advocate for something they believe in, and ultimately deliver a personal manifesto that synthesizes their communicative development across the program. The capstone session (Session 15) is the culminating experience of the course.

Week 5 Learning Outcomes

By the end of Week 5, the learner will be able to:

- Articulate a personal vision with specificity and conviction
- Deliver a persuasive mini-pitch on a topic they care about deeply
- Present a personal manifesto demonstrating growth across all six soft skills competencies

Sessions at a Glance

Session	Title	Soft Skill Focus
Session 13	Your Future Self	Visioning · Aspirational communication
Session 14	One Conversation at a Time	Advocacy · Passionate communication
Session 15	My Personal Manifesto	Capstone — All Six Competencies

PART IV

Detailed Session Plans

4.0 How to Read a Session Plan

Each session plan below is organized as follows:

- **Session Information Table:** Week, duration, soft skill focus, and optional reading/resource.
- **Learning Objectives:** The specific communicative behaviors the session is designed to develop.
- **Warm-Up (10 min):** A low-stakes entry point into the session's theme. The goal is to activate the learner's thinking and establish a conversational rhythm.
- **Core Discussion (30–35 min):** The heart of the session. Four to six discussion questions move from accessible to more complex. The facilitator should allow the conversation to develop organically; questions are jumping-off points, not a script.
- **Signature Activity (10–15 min):** A structured task that deepens engagement with the session's soft skill focus. Activities may include roleplay, paired reflection, opinion ranking, or spoken synthesis tasks.
- **Soft Skills Observation Focus:** Behavioral indicators for the facilitator to watch for during the session. These feed directly into the Session Progress Notes in Part VI.
- **Wrap-Up (5 min):** A closing reflection question to help the learner synthesize the experience.
- **Post-Session Notes:** Optional follow-up suggestions and facilitation tips for adapting the session.

Important Note on Discussion Questions

The questions provided are recommended starting points, not a mandatory sequence. A skilled facilitator will follow the learner's energy and interest. If one question generates a rich 20-minute conversation, stay with it. If another falls flat, move on. The questions are designed to cover the thematic territory, but the conversation is the course.

SESSION 1

Your Story So Far

Week	Week 1 — WHO ARE YOU?
Duration	50–60 minutes
Soft Skills Focus	Storytelling · Self-expression · Narrative structure
Suggested Reading / Resource	"The Power of Vulnerability" — TED Talk by Brené Brown (optional, pre-session)

Learning Objectives

- Construct and deliver a personal narrative with clear structure, detail, and emotional range
- Identify and articulate defining moments and turning points in their life story
- Establish a foundation of comfort and trust with the facilitator for the course ahead

Warm-Up (10 min)

Opening Prompt

"Give me three words that describe who you are right now — not who you were or who you want to be, but who you are right now. Why those three words?"

Core Discussion (30–35 min)

The following questions guide the session. Follow the learner's energy — not every question needs to be asked. Allow the conversation to develop naturally.

- **Q:** Tell me about a moment in your life that changed you. It doesn't need to be dramatic — but it was significant.
- **Q:** What's a story about yourself that you find yourself telling often? Why do you keep coming back to it?
- **Q:** If someone who had never met you was reading your life story, what would surprise them most?
- **Q:** What chapter of your life are you currently in? If this chapter had a title, what would it be?
- **Q:** What's a story from your life that you haven't told many people — not because it's a secret, but because you haven't found the right moment?

Signature Activity (10–15 min)

Life Highlights

Ask the learner to identify 3 to 5 defining moments in their life and briefly describe each. Encourage them to share not just what happened, but how it felt and what it meant. The focus is entirely on how they tell the story: Are they coherent? Do they use vivid detail? Does their voice carry emotion? After they have shared all highlights, ask: "If these moments were chapters in a book, what would that book be called?"

Soft Skills Observation Focus

Notice how the learner structures their narrative — do they move chronologically, thematically, or associatively? Observe the richness of their emotional vocabulary. Do they describe how things felt, or only what happened? Watch for moments when the learner seems most alive and engaged — these signal topics and themes to return to in future sessions.

Wrap-Up (5 min)

Closing Question

"What did you enjoy most about today's conversation? Was there anything that felt difficult to put into words? What would you want to come back to?"

Facilitator Notes & Adaptation Tips

This is a rapport-building session above all else. Do not rush to ask the next question; allow space for the learner to expand. If the learner seems reserved, begin with a lighter personal question and build gradually. The most important outcome of Session 1 is that the learner leaves feeling genuinely seen and listened to.

SESSION 2

What Matters Most

Week	Week 1 — WHO ARE YOU?
Duration	50–60 minutes
Soft Skills Focus	Values articulation · Clarity of thought · Authentic self-expression
Suggested Reading / Resource	Brené Brown's List of 30 Core Values (provided in Resource Bank); or article: "What Are Your Core Values?" (learner reads before session)

Learning Objectives

- Identify and clearly articulate their top personal values using specific language and examples
- Reflect on the relationship between stated values and lived experience
- Practice abstract-to-concrete communication: moving from a concept to a story that illustrates it

Warm-Up (10 min)

Opening Prompt

"If money and time were not factors — if you were guaranteed success at anything you chose — what would you spend your life doing? Why?"

Core Discussion (30–35 min)

The following questions guide the session. Follow the learner's energy — not every question needs to be asked. Allow the conversation to develop naturally.

- **Q:** What do you believe in that most people in your life might disagree with?
- **Q:** Think of a decision you made that felt truly right, even if it was difficult. What value were you honoring?
- **Q:** When have you compromised on something important to you? How did that feel?
- **Q:** What does "success" mean to you — not the standard definition, but your own?
- **Q:** If you could remove one thing from your life tomorrow that no longer reflects who you are, what would it be?

Signature Activity (10–15 min)

The Values Conversation

Present the learner with three pairs of values that are genuinely in tension with one another (suggested pairs: Freedom vs. Security; Ambition vs. Contentment; Loyalty vs. Independence; Creativity vs. Stability). For each pair, the learner chooses the value they most identify with and explains why, using an example from their life. After all three pairs, ask: "Looking at your choices, what do they reveal about who you are right now?"

Soft Skills Observation Focus

Observe the learner's capacity for abstract thinking — can they articulate a value clearly, or do they struggle to name it? Notice how they move from concept to example. Watch for values that seem to underlie multiple answers, as these can become recurring themes in future sessions. Note moments of hesitation or contradiction — these are rich points for gentle follow-up.

Wrap-Up (5 min)

Closing Question

"Pick one value you'd like to strengthen this year — not one you already have, but one you want more of. What would your life look like if that value were fully present?"

Facilitator Notes & Adaptation Tips

If the learner brought the values reading, use it as a starting point: ask them to share which values they resonated with and why. If not, have a printed or verbal list ready. The activity works best when the pairs feel genuinely hard to choose between — adjust the pairs to match what you already know about the learner.

SESSION 3

Habits & the Self

Week	Week 1 — WHO ARE YOU?
Duration	50–60 minutes
Soft Skills Focus	Self-awareness · Reflective thinking · Concrete vs. abstract communication
Suggested Reading / Resource	Atomic Habits — James Clear, Chapters 1–2 (optional pre-reading); or article: "How Habits Shape Your Identity" (facilitator may summarize key ideas if learner has not read)

Learning Objectives

- Articulate the relationship between daily habits and personal identity using specific examples
- Reflect critically on routines and behaviors rather than simply describing them
- Practice specificity in communication: moving from general statements to concrete illustrations

Warm-Up (10 min)

Opening Prompt

"Walk me through your ideal morning from the moment you wake up. Now walk me through your actual morning. What's the difference — and what does that difference tell you?"

Core Discussion (30–35 min)

The following questions guide the session. Follow the learner's energy — not every question needs to be asked. Allow the conversation to develop naturally.

- **Q:** What's a habit you're most proud of having built? How did you do it, and what did it take?
- **Q:** Do you think of yourself as more disciplined or more spontaneous? What's an example from the past week?
- **Q:** What habit — good or bad — do you think says the most about who you really are?
- **Q:** Is there something you keep trying to change about your routine and can't? What do you think is really stopping you?
- **Q:** James Clear argues that identity drives behavior: "I am the kind of person who..." Try completing that sentence three times. What do you notice?

Signature Activity (10–15 min)

The Habit Map

Ask the learner to identify three habits: one they are proud of, one they consider neutral, and one they want to change. For each, they answer three questions: (1) What triggers this habit? (2) What does it give them? (3) What does it reveal about who they are? The goal is to move beyond surface description to genuine reflection on behavior.

Soft Skills Observation Focus

Notice the learner's capacity for self-awareness — do they describe their behavior with clarity and honesty, or do they stay at the surface? Observe whether they can move from the general ("I'm not disciplined") to the specific ("I always skip the gym on Thursdays because..."). Strong specificity is a sign of communicative maturity. Note any defensiveness, as it may indicate a topic worth returning to gently.

Wrap-Up (5 min)

Closing Question

"What habit would the best version of you have that you don't have right now? What would it take to start it this week — just the first small step?"

Facilitator Notes & Adaptation Tips

This session works well when the facilitator also shares a brief personal example at the warm-up stage — it models the level of honesty and specificity you are inviting. Do not use the reading as a "lesson"; if the learner has read it, use it purely as a springboard for their own reflection.

SESSION 4

Seeing Through Another's Eyes

Week	Week 2 — THE ART OF CONNECTION
Duration	50–60 minutes
Soft Skills Focus	Empathy · Perspective-taking · Suspending judgment
Suggested Reading / Resource	"Brené Brown on Empathy" — RSA Animate (3 min, YouTube); or article: "What Empathy Is and Isn't" (any reputable source)

Learning Objectives

- Demonstrate perspective-taking through language, specifically using perspective-language framing ("From their point of view...", "I imagine they felt...")
- Reflect on personal limits of empathy — when it is easy and when it is genuinely difficult
- Discuss a real-life experience where truly understanding another person changed a situation

Warm-Up (10 min)

Opening Prompt

"Tell me about the last time you felt truly understood by someone. Not just heard — actually understood. What did they do that made you feel that way?"

Core Discussion (30–35 min)

The following questions guide the session. Follow the learner's energy — not every question needs to be asked. Allow the conversation to develop naturally.

- **Q:** Tell me about a time you changed your opinion about someone after really listening to them. What did you learn?
- **Q:** When do you find it hardest to be empathetic? What kinds of situations or people make empathy feel impossible?
- **Q:** Is it possible to fully understand someone from a very different background, culture, or life experience? Or is there always a wall?
- **Q:** Who in your life has taught you the most about empathy? What did they show you?
- **Q:** Do you think empathy can be learned, or is it a personality trait? What's your experience?

Signature Activity (10–15 min)

The Other Side

Present a brief scenario: "A colleague who is usually reliable was late to your most important meeting of the year and did not apologize." Ask the learner to give their instinctive reaction. Then ask: "Now generate five possible explanations for their behavior that have nothing to do with them being careless or disrespectful." After they do, ask: "How does having those five explanations change how you feel or how you'd respond?" Debrief: What is the difference between understanding someone and excusing them?

Soft Skills Observation Focus

Watch for the learner's capacity to suspend their first reaction and genuinely explore another perspective. Strong empathic language sounds like: "I imagine they might have been feeling...", "It's possible that from their perspective...", "I hadn't thought about it that way." Note moments of genuine surprise or insight — these indicate real empathic engagement, not just intellectual exercise.

Wrap-Up (5 min)

Closing Question

"Who in your life would benefit most from you being a little more empathetic right now? Not a lecture on what you should do — just: who is the person, and what might they be going through that you haven't fully considered?"

Facilitator Notes & Adaptation Tips

This session can become very rich when the learner connects the discussion to a real, current relationship in their life. Facilitate gently — you are not a therapist, but authentic connection to real experience is where the communication growth happens.

SESSION 5

When Words Fail

Week	Week 2 — THE ART OF CONNECTION
Duration	50–60 minutes
Soft Skills Focus	Assertive communication · Conflict navigation · Clarity under emotional pressure
Suggested Reading / Resource	"How to Have a Difficult Conversation" — Harvard Business Review (any recent article on this topic); or excerpt from Difficult Conversations by Stone, Patton & Heen

Learning Objectives

- Distinguish between passive, aggressive, and assertive communication using personal examples
- Articulate what makes a difficult conversation go well or badly
- Practice restating vague or passive language as clear, direct, assertive communication

Warm-Up (10 min)

Opening Prompt

"Think of a conversation you have been avoiding — with anyone, about anything. What is stopping you from having it? What's the worst that could realistically happen if you did?"

Core Discussion (30–35 min)

The following questions guide the session. Follow the learner's energy — not every question needs to be asked. Allow the conversation to develop naturally.

- **Q:** Tell me about a difficult conversation you handled well. What made it go the way it did?
- **Q:** Tell me about one that didn't go well. Looking back, what would you do differently?
- **Q:** Do you tend to be passive, aggressive, or assertive when you're in conflict? Is it always the same, or does it depend on who you're talking to?
- **Q:** When someone says something that upsets you, what is your first instinct — to say something, to go quiet, or to change the subject?
- **Q:** What's the difference between being direct and being unkind? Have you ever crossed that line?

Signature Activity (10–15 min)

Say What You Mean

Present three statements that are passive, vague, or indirect (examples: "Whatever, it's fine." / "I guess we could try it your way, if you want." / "I'm not sure, maybe someone should look at that eventually."). For each, the learner first identifies what the speaker probably actually means, then rewrites the statement to say it directly and assertively. Debrief: "What makes it hard to say these things clearly? What do we lose when we don't?"

Soft Skills Observation Focus

Notice how the learner talks about conflict. Do they minimize it? Take full ownership? Assign blame? Observe how they physically communicate about uncomfortable topics — voice softening, topic-changing. The goal is not to push them, but to notice and gently name what you observe. Watch for the use of "I" statements versus blame-language.

Wrap-Up (5 min)

Closing Question

"Is there something you would like to say to someone in your life right now that you haven't said? You don't need to tell me what it is — but what's the cost of not saying it?"

Facilitator Notes & Adaptation Tips

This session can become emotionally charged for some learners. Keep the energy light and curious rather than heavy. You are not asking them to resolve their conflicts — you are inviting them to think about how they communicate when things are hard.

SESSION 6

The Listening Advantage

Week	Week 2 — THE ART OF CONNECTION
Duration	50–60 minutes
Soft Skills Focus	Active listening · Empathic response · Rapport-building
Suggested Reading / Resource	Just Listen — Mark Goulston (selected excerpt); or article: "Are You Really Listening?" (any reputable business or psychology source)

Learning Objectives

- Articulate the difference between hearing and listening using personal examples
- Identify their own listening barriers and discuss strategies for overcoming them
- Demonstrate engaged listening through follow-up questions and reflective responses during the session itself

Warm-Up (10 min)

Opening Prompt

"Describe the best listener you know. Not a famous person — someone in your life. What exactly do they do that makes you feel listened to?"

Core Discussion (30–35 min)

The following questions guide the session. Follow the learner's energy — not every question needs to be asked. Allow the conversation to develop naturally.

- **Q:** What bad listening habits do you notice most often in others? Be honest — do you share any of them?
- **Q:** What is the difference between hearing someone and truly listening to them?
- **Q:** Have you ever been in a conversation where you realized you had stopped listening? What pulled you away?
- **Q:** Do you think it's possible to listen too much — to be so focused on listening that you stop contributing?
- **Q:** When do you do your best listening? What conditions make it easiest for you?

Signature Activity (10–15 min)

Listening Inventory

Present five common listening barriers: (1) Mental distraction / mind wandering; (2) Formulating your response before the other person has finished; (3) Emotional reaction to content; (4) Judgment of the speaker; (5) Assuming you already know what they're going to say. Ask the learner to rate themselves on each from 1 (rarely) to 5 (often), then choose the one barrier they most want to work on and explain why. Ask: "What would your most important relationships look like if you reduced that barrier by half?"

Soft Skills Observation Focus

This session is itself a listening exercise for the facilitator. Model the behaviors you are discussing: give the learner space, do not interrupt, ask follow-up questions that build on exactly what they said, and reflect back their language. Note how the learner responds to your listening behavior — do they open up more? Notice whether they ask you questions back, which is itself a strong indicator of active listening development.

Wrap-Up (5 min)

Closing Question

"One specific, concrete thing you could do before our next session to practice better listening — what is it? Make it small and very realistic."

Facilitator Notes & Adaptation Tips

Consider sharing your own listening challenges briefly — the vulnerability of the facilitator modeling honest self-reflection can significantly deepen the learner's engagement with this topic.

SESSION 7

Your Professional Identity

Week	Week 3 — WORK & AMBITION
Duration	50–60 minutes
Soft Skills Focus	Professional presence · Articulating expertise · Self-positioning
Suggested Reading / Resource	"Find Your Why" — article or excerpt from Start With Why, Simon Sinek; or any article on personal branding and professional identity

Learning Objectives

- Articulate their professional identity and personal "why" clearly and compellingly
- Describe their professional journey using specific examples and meaningful language
- Deliver a 60-second professional introduction with confidence and authentic energy

Warm-Up (10 min)

Opening Prompt

"Describe what you do professionally to someone who has never heard of your industry — a curious ten-year-old or your grandmother. Make it interesting."

Core Discussion (30–35 min)

The following questions guide the session. Follow the learner's energy — not every question needs to be asked. Allow the conversation to develop naturally.

- **Q:** What is your professional "why" — the deeper reason you do what you do, beyond the paycheck?
- **Q:** How do you want to be known professionally? If your colleagues were describing you to a stranger, what would you want them to say?
- **Q:** What's the most significant professional challenge you've overcome? What did it teach you about yourself?
- **Q:** How has your professional identity changed over the last five years? Are you the same professional you were?
- **Q:** Is there a gap between the professional you appear to be and the professional you know yourself to be?

Signature Activity (10–15 min)

Your 60-Second Professional Introduction

Ask the learner to introduce themselves professionally in exactly 60 seconds as if meeting a potential collaborator, employer, or client at an event. After they do, debrief together: What did they lead with? What did they leave out? What felt natural versus rehearsed? Then invite them to try it again — this time with one specific change they identified. The goal is not a polished "elevator pitch" but an authentic, confident articulation of who they are professionally.

Soft Skills Observation Focus

Observe professional vocabulary range and confidence. Does the learner speak with authority about their own expertise? Watch for overly modest language ("I just do...", "I'm only...") or inflated language that lacks specificity. Notice whether they can distinguish between what they do and why it matters — this is the mark of a communicatively sophisticated professional.

Wrap-Up (5 min)

Closing Question

"If you could add one dimension to your professional identity in the next year — a skill, a role, a reputation — what would it be? Why haven't you yet?"

Facilitator Notes & Adaptation Tips

This session is particularly adaptable based on the learner's career stage. For learners in transition, focus more on "who are you becoming professionally." For established professionals, push toward the "why" and the legacy question. For students or early-career learners, focus on how to articulate potential and aspiration authentically.

SESSION 8

Leadership in Words & Action

Week	Week 3 — WORK & AMBITION
Duration	50–60 minutes
Soft Skills Focus	Leadership communication · Influence · Adaptability of style
Suggested Reading / Resource	Leaders Eat Last — Simon Sinek (selected excerpt); or any article on leadership communication styles

Learning Objectives

- Articulate their own leadership style using specific examples from personal or professional experience
- Distinguish between managing people and leading them through language
- Respond to a leadership communication challenge with strategic, emotionally intelligent language

Warm-Up (10 min)

Opening Prompt

"Name someone you consider a great leader — not a historical figure or celebrity, but someone you have personally witnessed leading. What is one specific thing you have seen them do or say that makes them great?"

Core Discussion (30–35 min)

The following questions guide the session. Follow the learner's energy — not every question needs to be asked. Allow the conversation to develop naturally.

- **Q:** Do you think of yourself as a leader? In what areas of your life — not necessarily at work?
- **Q:** What is the difference between managing people and actually leading them?
- **Q:** How do you motivate people who are very different from you in personality or values?
- **Q:** What leadership style do you naturally gravitate toward? Is it always effective, or are there situations where it fails you?
- **Q:** Tell me about a time when you changed your mind about leadership — when you realized you had been doing it wrong.

Signature Activity (10–15 min)

The Leadership Dilemma

Present this scenario: "Your team has just experienced a significant project failure. The client is disappointed. The team is demoralized and defensive. You have five minutes with them before a critical meeting. What do you say?" The learner speaks for 2–3 minutes as the leader in that moment. Afterward, debrief: What communication choices did they make? What tone? What balance of accountability versus encouragement? What would they change?

Soft Skills Observation Focus

Notice the balance of "I" and "we" language in the learner's responses. Strong leadership communicators tend to attribute success to the team and take individual responsibility for failure. Observe whether the learner can shift between directive and supportive communication styles, and whether they show awareness that different people need different kinds of leadership.

Wrap-Up (5 min)

Closing Question

"What's one thing a great leader has said to you that you will never forget? Why did it stay with you?"

Facilitator Notes & Adaptation Tips

This session tends to reveal a lot about the learner's professional context and relational dynamics. Be attentive to the stories they share about leadership — they often illuminate the learner's deeper values and aspirations.

SESSION 9

Feedback as a Gift

Week	Week 3 — WORK & AMBITION
Duration	50–60 minutes
Soft Skills Focus	Constructive feedback delivery · Receiving criticism gracefully · Growth mindset communication
Suggested Reading / Resource	Radical Candor — Kim Scott (selected excerpt, Ch. 1); or article: "The Feedback Fallacy" (Marcus Buckingham & Ashley Goodall, HBR)

Learning Objectives

- Articulate what makes feedback constructive versus destructive using real examples
- Reflect honestly on their personal patterns around giving and receiving criticism
- Rewrite vague or unkind feedback as specific, kind, and actionable

Warm-Up (10 min)

Opening Prompt

"Tell me about a piece of feedback you received — positive or negative — that genuinely changed you. What was it, and why did it land?"

Core Discussion (30–35 min)

The following questions guide the session. Follow the learner's energy — not every question needs to be asked. Allow the conversation to develop naturally.

- **Q:** How do you honestly react when you receive criticism? Not how you think you should react — how you actually react.
- **Q:** What is the difference between feedback that is truly constructive and feedback that just feels critical?
- **Q:** Have you ever had to give someone difficult feedback? How did you approach it, and how did it go?
- **Q:** Do you actively seek feedback, or do you wait for it to come to you? What does that say about you?
- **Q:** Is there feedback you received years ago that you wish you had heard differently — or that you wish you had given more time to?

Signature Activity (10–15 min)

Reframe It

Present three examples of poorly delivered feedback: (1) Too blunt — "That presentation was a mess. You need to completely redo it." (2) Too vague — "Good effort. Keep working on it." (3) Unkind — "I don't know why you thought that approach would work." The learner rewrites each to be specific, honest, kind, and actionable. Debrief: "What changed in the language? What does better feedback require of the person giving it?"

Soft Skills Observation Focus

Observe whether the learner can separate their ego from the discussion of criticism. Do they speak about receiving feedback with openness or defensiveness? Note their vocabulary around growth — do they use fixed mindset language ("I'm just not good at that") or growth mindset language ("That's something I'm working on"). Watch for specific, actionable language in the activity — this is a strong indicator of professional communicative sophistication.

Wrap-Up (5 min)

Closing Question

"Who in your life gives you the best feedback? What makes it valuable — what is it about how they deliver it that makes you actually listen?"

Facilitator Notes & Adaptation Tips

This session pairs beautifully with Session 6 on listening. Consider connecting the two: "Receiving feedback well is fundamentally a listening skill." If the learner has a specific professional feedback challenge, the activity can be adapted to use real scenarios from their context.

SESSION 10

The News & You

Week	Week 4 — THINKING & PERSUADING
Duration	50–60 minutes
Soft Skills Focus	Media literacy · Structured opinion formation · Evidence-based argument
Suggested Reading / Resource	One current news article selected by the facilitator based on the learner's stated interests (prepare 2–3 options in advance). Article should be recent, substantive, and not politically extreme.

Learning Objectives

- Distinguish between fact, opinion, and interpretation in spoken and written sources
- Articulate and support a personal position on a current issue with clarity and evidence
- Reflect on their own media consumption habits and how they shape their worldview

Warm-Up (10 min)

Opening Prompt

"What is a story in the news lately that you cannot stop thinking about — or that made you feel something strong? Why that one?"

Core Discussion (30–35 min)

The following questions guide the session. Follow the learner's energy — not every question needs to be asked. Allow the conversation to develop naturally.

- **Q:** Where do you get your news? Do you trust it? How do you decide what to trust?
- **Q:** What's a topic in the world right now that you feel strongly about? What is your actual position on it?
- **Q:** How do you form your opinion on something new? What is your process — do you read, discuss, reflect?
- **Q:** Can you think of a time when a news story or piece of journalism genuinely changed how you saw something?
- **Q:** Do you think it's possible to be fully informed and still not know what to think? What do you do with that uncertainty?

Signature Activity (10–15 min)

Opinion or Fact?

Read five sentences from the article prepared in advance. For each, the learner identifies whether it is a fact, an opinion, or an interpretation — and explains why. Then choose one opinion in the article that the learner disagrees with. Ask them to make the case against it in 2–3 minutes, using language like "I disagree because...", "The evidence suggests that actually...", "A different way to read this is..."

Soft Skills Observation Focus

Observe the learner's epistemic vocabulary — do they distinguish between what they know, what they believe, and what they suspect? Watch for phrases like "I believe," "The evidence suggests," "In my view," "I'm not sure but..." These are markers of communicative and intellectual sophistication. Notice whether they can hold complexity — acknowledge that an issue is difficult while still forming a position.

Wrap-Up (5 min)

Closing Question

"What topic in the world right now do you want to understand better — not just have an opinion about, but actually understand more deeply? Let's use that as a starting point for next session."

Facilitator Notes & Adaptation Tips

The article selection matters enormously. Avoid anything highly politically charged or divisive; focus on topics that are interesting and substantive without being tribal. Good topics include: technology and society, environment and innovation, education, health, and urban change. Ask the learner in advance about their interests.

SESSION 11

Agree to Disagree

Week	Week 4 — THINKING & PERSUADING
Duration	50–60 minutes
Soft Skills Focus	Structured argumentation · Persuasion · Intellectual humility · Graceful disagreement
Suggested Reading / Resource	An opinion piece on a topic of the learner's choice (assigned at end of Session 10); or a classic persuasive essay on a topic relevant to the learner's stated interests

Learning Objectives

- Construct and deliver a structured argument for and against a position
- Demonstrate intellectual humility by acknowledging the strongest counterarguments to their own position
- Use the language of respectful disagreement: "I see your point, but...", "That's a fair argument, however...", "I hadn't considered that, but I still think..."

Warm-Up (10 min)

Opening Prompt

"What is a belief you hold — about life, work, people, anything — that you would be genuinely willing to have challenged today? Let's make it the basis of our session."

Core Discussion (30–35 min)

The following questions guide the session. Follow the learner's energy — not every question needs to be asked. Allow the conversation to develop naturally.

- **Q:** Tell me about a time you changed your mind on something important. Not something trivial — something that actually mattered to you. What convinced you?
- **Q:** Is it possible to disagree with someone deeply and still fully respect them? Give me a real example.
- **Q:** Do you enjoy debate and intellectual disagreement, or does it make you uncomfortable? Why?
- **Q:** What is a topic where you feel you might be wrong but keep defending your position anyway? What makes you hold on to it?
- **Q:** What's the difference between being persuaded by logic and being persuaded by emotion? Which works better on you?

Signature Activity (10–15 min)

Steel-Manning

Present a substantive but non-polarizing position (good examples: "Social media does more harm than good." / "Remote work is better than in-office work for most people." / "A university degree is no longer worth the cost."). Ask the learner to argue FOR the position as strongly as possible for 2 minutes, then AGAINST it as strongly as possible for 2 minutes. Debrief: Which side was easier? What did arguing the other side teach you? What is the strongest argument you could not easily answer?

Soft Skills Observation Focus

The most significant soft skill to observe in this session is intellectual flexibility. Can the learner genuinely inhabit a perspective they do not hold? Notice whether their language becomes more animated when defending a position they actually believe versus arguing a devil's advocate case. Also observe the language of concession: does it feel genuine ("That's actually a strong point") or defensive ("Sure, but...")?

Wrap-Up (5 min)

Closing Question

"What's one belief you have been holding tightly — maybe for years — that you might be willing to examine more honestly? You don't have to let go of it. Just: are you sure?"

Facilitator Notes & Adaptation Tips

Assign the passage selection for Session 12 here: "Between now and our next session, find a passage — from a book, an article, or any text — that has stayed with you. Something you have read that changed how you think. Bring it to share." This pre-assignment significantly enriches Session 12.

SESSION 12

Books That Changed You

Week	Week 4 — THINKING & PERSUADING
Duration	50–60 minutes
Soft Skills Focus	Critical reflection · Idea synthesis · Articulating abstract meaning · Connecting story to life
Suggested Reading / Resource	A passage chosen by the learner and brought to the session (pre-assigned in Session 11). Any text — book, article, essay — that has stayed with them.

Learning Objectives

- Explain the significance of a chosen text using specific references and personal connections
- Articulate how a story or idea has influenced their thinking, values, or behavior
- Engage with abstract ideas fluently, moving between concept and personal experience

Warm-Up (10 min)

Opening Prompt

"Tell me about the first book you remember loving. Not necessarily the best book you've read — the first one that made you feel something. What do you remember about the experience of reading it?"

Core Discussion (30–35 min)

The following questions guide the session. Follow the learner's energy — not every question needs to be asked. Allow the conversation to develop naturally.

- **Q:** Tell me about the passage or text you brought today. What is it, and why did you choose it?
- **Q:** What is a book — fiction or non-fiction — that genuinely changed the way you think or live?
- **Q:** What makes a story or idea stick with you long after you've finished it? What is that quality?
- **Q:** Do you prefer fiction or non-fiction? What does that preference tell you about how you learn?
- **Q:** Is there a character — from a book, a film, a series — who you feel is in some way a version of you?

Signature Activity (10–15 min)

The Passage

The learner shares or reads their chosen passage (3–5 minutes). The facilitator listens without comment. Then a guided conversation: "Why did you choose this? What does it mean to you — not what does it say, but what does it mean to you specifically? What does it make you think about right now, in your life? What does it ask of you?" Allow the conversation to follow the learner's associations freely.

Soft Skills Observation Focus

Observe the learner's ability to connect abstract ideas to personal experience. Do they stay at the level of summary ("it's about a person who...") or can they move to interpretation ("what it means to me is...")? Notice the emotional energy in their voice when they talk about the text — this often indicates what they truly care about. The choice of text itself is revealing.

Wrap-Up (5 min)

Closing Question

"What book do you want to read before the end of this year — not one you think you should read, but one you genuinely want to? And what does that tell us about where you are right now?"

Facilitator Notes & Adaptation Tips

This session has no fixed structure beyond the initial discussion. Follow the learner's passage wherever it leads. Some of the richest conversations in the course happen here. Do not rush back to the prepared questions — if the passage opens something meaningful, stay with it.

SESSION 13

Your Future Self

Week	Week 5 — VISION & IMPACT
Duration	50–60 minutes
Soft Skills Focus	Visioning · Aspirational language · Connecting present to future
Suggested Reading / Resource	The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People — Stephen Covey (Habit 2: Begin with the End in Mind); or any reflective article on personal vision and legacy

Learning Objectives

- Articulate a clear, specific, and emotionally resonant vision for their future
- Identify and name the obstacles — internal and external — between their present self and their desired future
- Deliver a spoken "letter to their future self" with confidence and authentic emotion

Warm-Up (10 min)

Opening Prompt

"Close your eyes for a moment if you're comfortable. It is ten years from today. Describe what you see: where are you, what are you doing, who is around you, and — most importantly — how do you feel?"

Core Discussion (30–35 min)

The following questions guide the session. Follow the learner's energy — not every question needs to be asked. Allow the conversation to develop naturally.

- **Q:** What does your best possible future look like in five to ten years? Not realistic — best possible.
- **Q:** What is genuinely stopping you from getting there? Not the standard answer — the real one.
- **Q:** What would you regret most if you reached the end of your life having never done it?
- **Q:** If your future self — ten years from now, having lived the life you most want — could send you one message right now, what would it say?
- **Q:** Do you have a clear vision of who you want to become, or is it still fuzzy? How does it feel to not have full clarity?

Signature Activity (10–15 min)

Letter to Your Future Self

Ask the learner to narrate — not write, but speak — a letter to themselves five years from now. They speak directly to their future self: "In five years, I hope you have...", "I hope you have learned...", "I hope you are proud of...", "I hope you have finally...". The facilitator listens actively and may ask one or two gentle clarifying questions during or after. The learner should speak for at least 3–4 minutes without stopping to think too long.

Soft Skills Observation Focus

Observe the specificity and emotional conviction of the learner's vision. A clear, well-articulated future tends to produce specific language ("I am running my own business in Lisbon and waking up without an alarm") versus vague aspiration ("I hope things are better"). Notice the emotional tone: is it hopeful, anxious, resigned, determined? These are soft skills indicators. Also observe how they talk about obstacles — with agency or with passivity.

Wrap-Up (5 min)

Closing Question

"What is one thing — small and concrete — that you will do this week, this month, because your future self is counting on you? Name it specifically."

Facilitator Notes & Adaptation Tips

Pre-assign for Session 14: Ask the learner to identify a social issue, a cause, or a topic they care deeply about. They will have 2 minutes in the next session to pitch you on why you should care about it too. It can be large-scale or small — what matters is that they genuinely care.

SESSION 14

One Conversation at a Time

Week	Week 5 — VISION & IMPACT
Duration	50–60 minutes
Soft Skills Focus	Advocacy · Passionate communication · Inspiring through language · Emotional conviction
Suggested Reading / Resource	A TED Talk transcript on a topic of the learner's choosing, related to a social cause or issue they care about (learner selects; facilitator may suggest two or three options)

Learning Objectives

- Deliver a 2-minute persuasive pitch on a topic they care about deeply, with emotional conviction and specific reasoning
- Reflect on what makes communication genuinely inspiring versus merely informative
- Discuss the relationship between language, passion, and social change

Warm-Up (10 min)

Opening Prompt

"What problem in the world — big or small, global or local — makes you genuinely angry? Not just worried or concerned. Angry. Why that one?"

Core Discussion (30–35 min)

The following questions guide the session. Follow the learner's energy — not every question needs to be asked. Allow the conversation to develop naturally.

- **Q:** What cause, issue, or topic would you dedicate your life to if you could dedicate it to only one thing?
- **Q:** Have you ever tried to persuade someone to care about something you care about? What happened?
- **Q:** What makes someone a genuinely compelling advocate for a cause — not just someone who talks about it, but someone who actually moves people?
- **Q:** Who inspires you in the way they speak about what they believe in? What is it specifically that they do?
- **Q:** Do you think one person can actually change something through the power of conversation and communication? Or is that naive?

Signature Activity (10–15 min)

The 2-Minute Pitch

The learner has 2 minutes to convince the facilitator to genuinely care about the topic they pre-selected. The facilitator plays the role of a thoughtful, skeptical but open-minded person who has not thought much about the issue before. After the pitch, the facilitator gives honest feedback not on content but on communication: "What made me lean in? What made me less sure? What would have made me more convinced?" Then invite a second attempt with one specific change.

Soft Skills Observation Focus

Observe the presence of genuine emotional conviction — does the learner's voice change when they talk about something they care about? Watch for the ability to make an abstract cause feel personal and concrete ("Let me tell you about one person whose life changed because of this..."). Note the balance of emotion and evidence — the most powerful advocates use both. This session also shows how the learner has grown across the course in confidence and authenticity.

Wrap-Up (5 min)

Closing Question

"What did you learn about yourself as a communicator today? Not about the topic — about yourself and how you communicate when something really matters to you."

Facilitator Notes & Adaptation Tips

Pre-assign the capstone for Session 15: "Between now and our final session, prepare a 5 to 7-minute personal statement. It can take any form you like. It should answer, in some way, these three questions: Who are you? What do you stand for? Where are you going? You can write it, plan it, or simply think about it. The goal is to speak, not to perform."

SESSION 15

My Personal Manifesto

Week	Week 5 — VISION & IMPACT
Duration	60 minutes (slightly extended)
Soft Skills Focus	All six soft skills competencies · Confident self-presentation · Authentic voice · Synthesis
Suggested Reading / Resource	No assigned reading. This session is entirely learner-led.

Learning Objectives

- Deliver a personal manifesto of 5–7 minutes that synthesizes their communicative development across the five-week program
- Reflect on their growth as a communicator with specificity and genuine self-awareness
- Engage in a meaningful closing conversation that honors the journey of the course

Warm-Up (10 min)

Opening Prompt

"Before you share your manifesto, tell me how you are feeling right now. Are you ready? Is there anything you want to say before you begin?"

Core Discussion (30–35 min)

The following questions guide the session. Follow the learner's energy — not every question needs to be asked. Allow the conversation to develop naturally.

- **Q:** Learner delivers their personal manifesto (5–7 minutes, uninterrupted).
- **Q:** Facilitator asks: "What part of what you said felt most true? Which part surprised you?"
- **Q:** What has changed in the way you communicate over these five weeks — in what you say, or in how you say it?
- **Q:** What skill do you most want to continue developing? What will you do to keep it growing?
- **Q:** What conversation do you want to have — with someone in your life — that you could not have had five weeks ago?

Signature Activity (20–25 min)

The Manifesto

The learner delivers their personal manifesto. The facilitator listens actively and without interruption for the full duration. After the learner finishes, the facilitator takes a deliberate 20–30 second pause before responding — honoring what was said. Then begin the reflection dialogue: "What came through most clearly? What in your voice changed when you talked about [specific topic]? What did you leave out that you wanted to include?"

Soft Skills Observation Focus

This is a comprehensive observation session. Look for evidence of all six soft skills competencies: Is there coherent narrative structure (Self-expression)? Does the learner acknowledge others and their relationships (Empathy)? Do they defend positions (Critical thinking)? Do they talk about their professional life with authority (Professional communication)? Is there genuine conviction and presence (Authentic voice)? Use the Soft Skills Observation Rubric in Part VI to score the capstone session.

Wrap-Up (5 min)

Closing Question

"What I noticed about you as a communicator today — and what I have noticed across these five weeks — is this: [Facilitator offers a genuine, specific, personal observation of the learner's communicative growth]. What do you want to carry forward from this experience?"

Facilitator Notes & Adaptation Tips

The facilitator's closing observation in the Wrap-Up is one of the most powerful moments of the course. Prepare it — do not improvise. It should be specific, authentic, and focused on communicative behavior, not general praise. End the session on whatever note feels most true: some learners will leave energized, others reflective, others emotional. All of these are exactly right.

PART V

Teacher's Facilitation Guide

5.1 The Teacher as Facilitator

ARTICULATE is not a teaching course. It is a facilitation experience. This distinction is not semantic — it fundamentally changes what the instructor does in the room. A teacher has a lesson plan, a grammar point, and an error correction protocol. A facilitator has a question, a genuine curiosity about the person in front of them, and a commitment to following the conversation wherever it leads.

The facilitator's primary tools are not explanations but questions — and not just any questions, but the kind that invite the learner to go deeper, be more specific, be more honest. The facilitator listens more than they speak. They reflect back what they hear. They ask "what do you mean by that?" and "can you give me an example?" more than they offer information.

The Facilitator's Guiding Principles

1. The learner is the expert on their own experience. Your job is to draw it out, not to supply it.
2. Silence is not failure. It is thinking. Give the learner at least 5–7 full seconds before prompting.
3. Never correct language unless the learner explicitly asks for it. Interrupting for correction destroys flow and trust.
4. Follow energy, not the plan. If a topic catches fire, stay with it. If a question falls flat, move on.
5. Model the behaviors you are developing. Listen actively, express your own views honestly, and show genuine curiosity.
6. End every session with the learner feeling more capable and more themselves, not evaluated.

5.2 Creating a Psychologically Safe Space

The quality of the communication that happens in ARTICULATE sessions is directly proportional to the learner's sense of safety. Safety in this context means: I will not be judged. I will not be corrected. I will not be rushed. My stories and opinions are welcome here.

Several structural features of ARTICULATE are designed to create this safety: the absence of assessment grades, the one-on-one format (no performance anxiety in front of peers), and the thematic focus on topics the learner has selected or endorsed. But structure is not enough — the facilitator must actively cultivate warmth, genuine interest, and consistent positive regard.

- **At the start of each session:** Begin with a light check-in. "How are you today — one word?" or simply "How was your week?" This is not wasted time; it is the foundation of trust.
- **On personal topics:** If a learner shares something vulnerable or difficult, respond to the person before returning to the course content. "That sounds like it was really hard. Thank you for sharing that."

- **When a learner struggles to articulate:** Resist the urge to rephrase for them. Instead, encourage: "Take your time. I'm in no hurry." Or: "Try it a different way. What is the feeling, even if the words aren't quite right yet?"
- **On cultural and experiential difference:** Genuine curiosity beats performative sensitivity. The best way to honor a learner's background is to ask about it with real interest and listen carefully to what they say.

5.3 How to Select and Use Readings

Readings in ARTICULATE serve as conversation launchers, not as texts to be analyzed, summarized, or discussed linguistically. The facilitator's task is to identify a passage, article, or excerpt that will spark a genuine, personal conversation — not to ensure the learner "understands the text."

Two approaches work well. In the first, the facilitator selects a text based on their knowledge of the learner's interests and introduces it briefly at the start of the session: "I found this article about [topic] and thought of you. I'll read you one paragraph — and then tell me what it makes you think about." In the second, the learner selects the text themselves (as in Sessions 11, 12, and 14) and brings it to share. Learner-selected texts tend to generate the richest conversations.

Rules for Using Readings in ARTICULATE

- Never quiz the learner on the text. Comprehension is not the goal.
- Use the text as a starting point, then put it aside. The conversation is the course.
- If the learner says they have not done the reading, simply proceed without it.
- If a reading generates a powerful conversation, abandon the remaining session questions and follow the conversation.
- If a reading does not resonate, acknowledge it and move on. "This one didn't quite land for you — what would be more interesting?"

5.4 Managing Silence, Hesitation & Difficulty

Silence is one of the most valuable moments in a one-on-one session, and one of the most frequently mismanaged by new facilitators. When a learner goes quiet, the instinct is to fill the space. Resist it.

Most productive silences in ARTICULATE fall into three categories: thinking silence (the learner is genuinely working through a complex idea), emotional silence (the learner has touched something that matters and needs a moment), and linguistic silence (the learner knows what they want to say but cannot find the words in English). Each requires a slightly different response:

- **Thinking silence:** Wait. Count to seven silently. Often the learner will continue with something richer than anything you could have prompted.
- **Emotional silence:** Acknowledge it gently: "Take your time." If the silence persists: "You don't have to say anything about that if you'd rather not."
- **Linguistic silence:** After a few seconds, offer a soft prompt: "Can you describe the feeling, even if the exact words aren't there?" Or: "Try it in whatever way works — we can find the better words together."

5.5 Adapting to Different Communication Styles

Learners come to ARTICULATE with widely different communication styles. Some are expansive natural talkers who need help going deeper rather than longer. Others are quiet, reflective communicators who give short answers and need gentle encouragement to develop. Still others are intellectually confident but emotionally guarded, or emotionally open but intellectually hesitant.

- **With expansive communicators:** Practice active interruption: "Wait — that detail you just mentioned: tell me more about that. Let's stay there." Help them develop depth over breadth.
- **With quiet or reserved communicators:** Increase the warm-up time. Use lower-stakes questions first. Be genuinely patient with short answers — follow up rather than prompting a fresh question. "You said [X]. Can you tell me more about that?"
- **With intellectually oriented learners:** Weeks 3 and 4 will be their strongest territory. In Weeks 1 and 2, gently invite them toward the personal: "Intellectually, you understand this completely. But what has been your experience of it?"
- **With emotionally expressive learners:** Honor the emotion, then gently bring structure: "That feels really important. How would you say it if you had to explain it to someone who had never experienced it?"

5.6 Session Customization Guide

ARTICULATE is designed to be personalized. The Student Profile Form (Part VII) gives the facilitator a detailed picture of the learner's interests, communication goals, and professional context before the course begins. The following guidelines help translate that profile into session-level customization:

- **Swap readings:** The suggested readings are starting points. If the learner is a business professional, articles from the Financial Times or Harvard Business Review may resonate more than a Brené Brown TED Talk. If they are an artist or writer, literary essays or author interviews may be more generative.
- **Adapt the activity:** Every Signature Activity can be adjusted in scope, topic, or format. The activity is a structure — the content is always the learner's own.
- **Repeat themes:** If a learner is deeply engaged with a theme (say, leadership in Week 3), a facilitator may decide to extend it into Week 4's first session rather than moving on. The five-week arc is recommended, not mandatory.
- **Adjust the pace:** Some learners move through questions quickly; others need an entire session to explore a single question deeply. Always follow the learner's pace, not the plan's pace.

PART VI

Assessment & Evaluation Framework

6.1 Philosophy of Assessment in ARTICULATE

Assessment in ARTICULATE is observation-based, non-graded, and non-linguistic. The goal of assessment is not to evaluate what the learner says but how they communicate — the behavioral indicators of soft skills growth that emerge over the five-week arc.

The facilitator functions as a trained observer. Using the Soft Skills Observation Rubric below, they document specific communicative behaviors after each session. Over the course of fifteen sessions, these observations create a detailed portrait of the learner's communicative development — one that is far more nuanced and meaningful than any grammar test or vocabulary assessment could produce.

Assessment Principles

- No grades, scores, or comparisons to other learners — ever.
- Assessment is formative (session-by-session observation) and summative (capstone and end-of-course reflection).
- Feedback to the learner is always framed as observation and encouragement, never as correction.
- The learner is invited to self-assess at the end of each session and at the end of the course.
- The capstone session (Session 15) serves as the summative assessment moment.

6.2 Soft Skills Observation Rubric

Use this rubric to observe and document communicative behavior across sessions. For each competency, identify where the learner currently falls and what growth looks like.

Competency	Emerging	Developing	Proficient
Self-Awareness & Expression	Provides very short answers; struggles to elaborate on personal topics; narrative lacks structure or detail	Can describe experiences and feelings with some elaboration; shows growing ability to identify significant moments; narrative becoming more coherent	Constructs rich, structured personal narratives; identifies and articulates values and beliefs clearly; speaks about inner life with nuance and specificity
Active Listening	Does not build on facilitator's statements; frequently changes subject; does not ask follow-up questions; shows signs of formulating response before facilitator finishes	Sometimes acknowledges and builds on what was said; beginning to ask clarifying questions; occasional reflective paraphrasing	Consistently builds on previous statements; asks genuine follow-up questions; paraphrases accurately; signals engagement through language and presence
Empathy &	Tends to respond with own	Beginning to acknowledge	Consistently adopts

Competency	Emerging	Developing	Proficient
Emotional Intelligence	perspective immediately; limited perspective-language; difficulty acknowledging emotional complexity	other perspectives before asserting own; uses some emotional vocabulary; can identify different sides of a situation	perspective-language; demonstrates nuanced emotional vocabulary; connects logically and emotionally to differing viewpoints; shows genuine curiosity about others' experiences
Critical Thinking & Argumentation	Difficulty distinguishing opinion from fact; avoids defending a position; responds to questions with "I don't know" or changes subject	Beginning to form and express opinions; uses some evidence; acknowledges some counterarguments with prompting	Consistently forms and supports positions with evidence and reasoning; acknowledges strongest counterarguments; uses epistemic vocabulary (I believe, the evidence suggests, in my view)
Professional Communication	Difficulty explaining professional role with clarity; uses vague or overly modest language; limited professional vocabulary	Can explain their role clearly; beginning to articulate professional values and goals; developing professional vocabulary and register	Articulates professional identity, values, and expertise compellingly; adapts register to context; communicates with authority and specificity in professional scenarios
Confidence & Authentic Voice	Voice very quiet or hesitant; frequent hedging and self-interruption; tends to minimize own ideas; body language suggests discomfort	Growing confidence; fewer excessive hedges; longer utterances; occasional moments of clear conviction and direct statement	Speaks with conviction and clarity; comfortable with silence; uses direct, specific language; voice and energy shift meaningfully when topic is personally meaningful

6.3 Session Progress Notes Template

Facilitators should complete brief progress notes after each session. The following template provides a consistent structure for these observations.

Session	Details
Session # / Date	_____
Topic / Theme	_____
Strongest Communication Moment	What did the learner say or do that showed real communicative growth?

Soft Skill Observation	Which competency was most visible? Describe a specific behavior.
Area for Growth	What communicative behavior do you want to watch for in the next session?
Facilitator Notes	Topics to return to, learner mood, contextual notes, or preparation for next session.

6.4 End-of-Course Reflection

At the conclusion of Session 15, both the facilitator and the learner complete a final reflection. The facilitator's reflection draws on their 15 sessions of progress notes to produce a comprehensive communicative portrait. The learner's reflection invites them to self-assess their growth and articulate their intentions going forward.

End-of-Course Learner Reflection Questions

1. What is the biggest change you notice in the way you communicate now compared to five weeks ago?
2. Which of the six soft skills competencies do you feel has grown most? What happened that caused that growth?
3. What conversation have you had in your life outside these sessions that felt different — easier, richer, more confident — because of this course?
4. What is one communicative behavior you want to continue developing beyond this course?
5. What does your communicative voice sound like now? How would you describe it?

PART VII

Resource Bank

7.1 Suggested Books

The following books are recommended as sources for reading excerpts, discussion topics, and thematic inspiration. Facilitators should read at least the chapter summaries of any book before using it in a session. Learners do not need to have read these books; passages are used as conversation launchers only.

For Self-Expression & Identity (Week 1)

- **Atomic Habits — James Clear:** Chapters 1–3 explore the relationship between habits and identity. Key phrase: "You do not rise to the level of your goals; you fall to the level of your systems."
- **Daring Greatly — Brené Brown:** Explores vulnerability, worthiness, and authentic self-presentation. Excellent for Session 2 on values.
- **Man's Search for Meaning — Viktor Frankl:** For learners interested in meaning, purpose, and identity under pressure. Best used in Week 1 or Week 5.

For Empathy & Relationships (Week 2)

- **Just Listen — Mark Goulston:** Practical, conversational guide to deep listening. Session 6 excerpt recommended.
- **Emotional Intelligence — Daniel Goleman:** The foundational text on emotional intelligence. Chapter 3 or 5 works well for Session 4.
- **Difficult Conversations — Stone, Patton & Heen:** Essential reading for Session 5. Chapter 1 or 2 recommended.

For Professional Communication (Week 3)

- **Start With Why / Leaders Eat Last — Simon Sinek:** Both books explore leadership and purpose-driven communication. Chapters 1–3 of either work for Sessions 7 and 8.
- **Radical Candor — Kim Scott:** The best available text on giving and receiving feedback. Chapter 1 is essential reading for Session 9.
- **The First 90 Days — Michael Watkins:** For learners in transition or new to a role; excellent for Session 7.

For Critical Thinking & Ideas (Week 4)

- **Thinking, Fast and Slow — Daniel Kahneman:** For advanced learners; excellent for discussing how we form opinions and make decisions.
- **The Art of Thinking Clearly — Rolf Dobelli:** Short, accessible chapters on cognitive biases. Perfect for Session 10 or 11.
- **A Room of One's Own — Virginia Woolf:** For learners interested in literature and ideas; excellent for Session 12.

For Vision & Impact (Week 5)

- **The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People — Stephen Covey:** Habit 2 (Begin with the End in Mind) is essential for Session 13.
- **Long Walk to Freedom — Nelson Mandela:** For learners interested in advocacy and resilience; excellent for Session 14.
- **Big Magic — Elizabeth Gilbert:** For learners interested in creativity, courage, and living an authentic life; excellent for Week 5.

7.2 Suggested Articles & Essays

The following article topics are recommended. Facilitators should search for current, reputable versions of these articles before the relevant session. Sources such as The Atlantic, The Guardian, Harvard Business Review, The New Yorker, Aeon, and TED Ideas are excellent.

- **Session 2:** "What Are Your Core Values?" — Any reputable life-design or coaching publication; alternatively, Brené Brown's values list (freely available online).
- **Session 5:** "How to Have a Difficult Conversation" — Harvard Business Review or any related article on assertive communication.
- **Session 7:** "What Is Your Professional Brand?" or "Finding Your Professional Why" — LinkedIn, HBR, or business press.
- **Session 9:** "The Feedback Fallacy" — Marcus Buckingham & Ashley Goodall, Harvard Business Review (2019). One of the most cited pieces on the science of feedback.
- **Session 10:** Choose one substantive current-events article related to the learner's professional or personal interests. Avoid politically extreme sources.
- **Session 13:** "The Power of Imagining Your Future Self" — Psychology Today or similar.

7.3 Recommended TED Talks

TED Talks are particularly effective in ARTICULATE because they model passionate, structured communication on meaningful topics — precisely the kind of communication the course develops. Transcripts are freely available on ted.com for reading-based use.

- **"The Power of Vulnerability" — Brené Brown (2010):** Session 1. 20 minutes. On authenticity, shame, and the courage of self-expression.
- **"Brené Brown on Empathy" — RSA Animate (2013):** Session 4. 3 minutes. The clearest, most accessible explanation of empathy available.

- **"How to Speak so That People Want to Listen" — Julian Treasure (2013):** Sessions 6/7. 10 minutes. On voice, listening, and the qualities of compelling communication.
- **"How Great Leaders Inspire Action" — Simon Sinek (2009):** Session 8. 18 minutes. The foundational TED Talk on purpose-driven leadership communication.
- **"The Danger of a Single Story" — Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie (2009):** Sessions 4/12. 19 minutes. On perspective, narrative, and how stories shape our understanding of others.
- **"Your Body Language May Shape Who You Are" — Amy Cuddy (2012):** Session 7 or 15. 21 minutes. On confidence, presence, and how we communicate nonverbally.
- **"Do Schools Kill Creativity?" — Sir Ken Robinson (2006):** Session 11 or 12. 19 minutes. Classic TED Talk suitable for learners interested in education and creativity.

7.4 Core Values Reference List

The following list may be used in Session 2 (What Matters Most). The learner reviews the list and identifies their top five to ten values as a starting point for discussion. This list is drawn from Brené Brown's values research.

Accountability	Authenticity	Balance	Belonging
Compassion	Courage	Creativity	Curiosity
Dignity	Discipline	Empathy	Excellence
Faith	Family	Freedom	Friendship
Fun	Generosity	Gratitude	Growth
Honesty	Hope	Humility	Humor
Inclusion	Independence	Integrity	Intuition
Justice	Kindness	Leadership	Learning
Legacy	Love	Loyalty	Meaning
Openness	Optimism	Order	Patience
Presence	Respect	Responsibility	Security
Service	Simplicity	Spirituality	Trust

7.5 Student Profile Form

Complete this form with the learner before Session 1, either via a brief intake conversation or by sharing it as a written questionnaire. This profile directly informs session customization across the five weeks.

ARTICULATE — Learner Profile Form

Name: _____ Preferred Language for Notes: _____

Professional Background / Field: _____

Why are you taking this course? What do you want to be able to do or say that you cannot do or say well right now? _____

What topics make you most excited to talk about? (Check all that apply:)

- | | | |
|---|---|---|
| ☐ Personal stories & life experience | ☐ Current events & world affairs | ☐ Science & technology |
| ☐ Art, music, film & literature | ☐ Work, leadership & business | ☐ Philosophy & ideas |
| ☐ Sports & physical wellbeing | ☐ Family & relationships | ☐ Other: _____ |

Is there a topic you would rather not discuss? _____

Do you have a book, article, or idea you'd love to discuss in one of our sessions? _____

How do you usually feel when speaking English? Circle: Very anxious / A little nervous / Comfortable / Confident

What soft skill do you most want to develop? (Circle one)

Active Listening • Storytelling • Argumentation • Empathy • Professional presence • Confidence

Is there anything else I should know about you as a communicator? _____

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ARTICULATE: A Five-Week Communication & Soft Skills Program

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